Although the target selection was settled, the question remained of how to extract the fidayeen. In his meetings with Iqbal and Sajid in late June, Headley found that both continued to view the egress option as viable. The plan was for the fidayeen to take a bus or train to Indian-administered Kashmir, where they would remain following the attacks. However, when Headley traveled back to Mumbai for the month of July he assessed potential attack venues from the perspective of a 'strong-hold option,' and by August most agreed the egress option would be difficult. Later that month, with only a short window of time before the attacks were supposed to be launched, Lashkar's leaders embraced the idea of executing a martyrdom operation. Kasab and his fellow would-be fidayeen were shifted back to Muridke after completing the Daura-e-Khasa program.[108] According to Headley's testimony, the purpose was to indoctrinate them further on the importance of martyrdom. Hafiz Saeed, Abdul Rehman Makki and others lectured to them during this time.[109]

Executing an operation in which the fidayeen fought to the death, rather than a series of hit-and-run strikes, contributed to the duration of the attacks and hence their spectacular nature. But the decision to do so was driven partly by operational necessity, and its last-minute nature may help to explain the need for Lashkar handlers to communicate electronically to the fidayeen throughout the course of the attacks. Another consequence of dropping the egress option was to shift the Chhatrapati Shivaji Terminus from an exfiltration point to a target, from which Kasab and Abu Ismail fled. Notably, they were the only ones not in touch with Lashkar handlers during the course of the Mumbai attacks. The interception of Lashkar's electronic communications coupled with Kasab's capture robbed it of plausible deniability. However, neither the group, nor its ISI handlers, could have reasonably assumed their involvement would not be presumed even if the operation had gone according to plan. The difference lay in what the Indian government knew or suspected and what it could prove. This meant that in an ideal scenario it was conceivable to deny involvement, as Lashkar had in previous instances, while still sending a message to the Indian government and, in doing so, possibly spoil the peace process. Further, the group never had any intention of hiding its involvement from the jihadi community.

According to Kasab, one of Lashkar's leaders motivated them by declaiming that for fifteen years the group had been fighting for Kashmir,